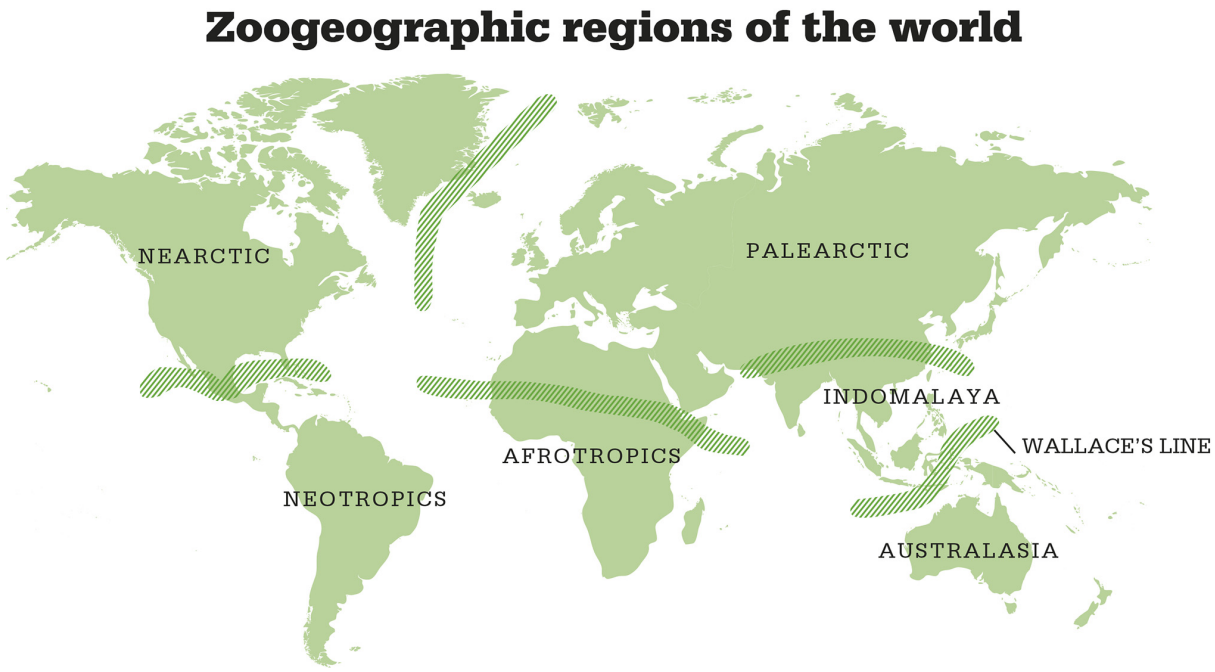


Wallace’s six zoogeographic regions began with the line he proposed in 1859 to mark the division of fauna between Southeast Asia and Australasia.

Wallace’s Line

During his 1854–62 expedition to the Malay Archipelago, Wallace collected an astonishing 126,000 specimens, many of them from species unknown to Western science, including 2 percent of the world’s bird species. He regarded biogeography as support for the theory of evolution by means of natural selection. One of Wallace’s important findings was the marked difference in bird species on either side of what was to become known as the Wallace Line, which runs along the Makassar Strait (between the islands of Borneo and Sulawesi) and the Lombok Strait (between Bali and Lombok); this separates Asian fauna from the Australasian. He found that larger mammals and most birds did not cross the line. For example, tigers and rhinos live only on the Asian side; babirusas, marsupials, and sulfur-breasted cockatoos only on the other side. He also highlighted the sharp differences between animals in North and South America.